Electorates' Responses to AI-Generated and Human-Created Campaign Messages in South-South Nigeria Ahead of the 2027 General Elections: An Exploratory Qualitative Study

Uka Nwagbara

Department of Advertising and Marketing Communications, Faculty of Communication and Media Studies, University of Uyo, Uyo

Precious Ukeje

Department of Mass Communication, Faculty of Communication and Media Studies, University of Uyo, Uyo

Daramfon Okon

Department of Information and Media Studies, Faculty of Communication and Media Studies, University of Uyo, Uyo

Abstract

Artificial intelligence is reshaping how political campaigns are produced and circulated. In Nigeria, parties, candidates, and supporters now rely heavily on digital tools to create adverts, images, and voice messages, yet little is known about how ordinary electorates in South-South Nigeria read such content. This exploratory study therefore examined how registered voters in South-South Nigeria distinguish AI-generated from human-created campaign messages, explain their trust or distrust in them, and describe their emotional responses and possible voting intentions ahead of the 2027 elections. A qualitative exploratory design was used. Nineteen registered voters aged 18 - 40 who actively use social media were purposively selected for maximum variation. Data were collected through online semi-structured interviews using six campaign messages, along with observation notes, and analysed with reflexive thematic analysis. Participants identified AI mainly through unnatural movement, implausible settings and contextual inconsistencies. Human-created messages were generally trusted more, although emotionally relevant AI content could also appear credible. Emotional reactions included humour, hope, confusion and worry, but these rarely translated directly into voting intention. Within this sample, recognition, trust and voting responses depended on realism, relevance, prior knowledge and candidate credibility. As exploratory findings, these are not statistically generalisable but offer propositions for larger, representative studies.

Keywords: Generative AI, Political communication, Campaign messages, Electorates, Trust, Recognition, Credibility, Emotions, Voting intention, Nigeria

Introduction

Generative artificial intelligence (AI) is reshaping political communication by enabling campaigns to produce persuasive text, images, audio and video quickly and cheaply (Hassim & Nasir, 2025; Beacken et al., 2026). Globally, experiments show that large-language-model messages can shift political attitudes, but effects vary by issue, audience, and message design; persuasive capacity, therefore, does not automatically imply greater influence than human communication (Bai et al., 2025; Jungherr et al., 2026). Research further shows that citizens judge deceptive AI uses more negatively than routine campaign applications, while many people struggle to distinguish AI- from human-generated information (Jungherr et al., 2026; Stefkovics & Gere, 2026).

Across Africa, digitally networked elections combine wider participation with greater exposure to misleading political content (Gadjanova et al., 2022; Abboud et al., 2024). However, literature has largely examined social-media campaigning, misinformation, digital literacy and the wider democratic consequences of internet use rather than directly comparing electorates' responses to AI-generated and human-created campaign

messages (Cariolle et al., 2024; Muringa & Adjin-Tettey, 2024; Mustapha et al., 2024). Emerging research has begun to document the use and risks of generative-AI propaganda in African elections (Wack & Parry, 2025; Wack & Prochaska, 2026), including Nigeria (Uzuegbunam, 2026; Beacken et al., 2026), but remains primarily concerned with disinformation threats, governance and countermeasures rather than how electorates recognise message origin, form trust judgements, experience emotional responses or translate such responses into voting intentions.

The studies reviewed above leave three specific gaps. First, on recognition, Nigerian studies have examined WhatsApp campaigning (Fisher et al., 2024), influencer-led influence operations (Uwalaka et al., 2025) and campaign responses to disinformation (Ibrahim & Ekdale, 2026), but none asked electorates to distinguish AI-generated from human-created messages. International evidence on this question is mixed: AI messages can persuade (Bai et al., 2025), people often cannot tell AI-generated from human-written content (Stefkovics & Gere, 2026), and deceptive AI use attracts public disapproval (Jungherr et al., 2026). Second, on trust, the Nigerian studies closest to this topic examined consumer trust in AI-generated advertising (Ekanem & Nwagbara, 2024), the role of AI-generated videos in one candidate's social identity (Nwaoboli & Ojete, 2025) and South-South voters' trust in algorithm-curated political messages (Abdulazeez et al., 2026); none compared trust in AI-generated and human-created campaign messages from the electorate's perspective. Third, on emotions and voting intention, Nigerian evidence comes from a single university's students (Ngoka et al., 2026) or from campaign actors rather than voters (Ibrahim & Ekdale, 2026), and does not address AI-generated content. Because the phenomenon is new and these questions have not been mapped in this region, an exploratory approach that builds in-depth understanding and generates propositions for later testing is more appropriate than a confirmatory one (Stebbins, 2001).

Given these gaps, this exploratory study examined how electorates in South-South Nigeria perceive and respond to AI-generated and human-created campaign messages ahead of the 2027 general elections. Specifically, it sought to:

Identify the cues electorates use to distinguish AI-generated from human-created campaign messages.

Explore the reasons electorates give for trusting or distrusting each type of campaign message.

Describe the emotional responses that the campaign messages evoke among electorates.

Explore how electorates perceive the campaign messages as shaping their voting intentions for the 2027 general elections.

Conceptual Clarification: Electorates, Responses and Campaign Messages

In legal terms, electorates are people qualified to vote; in Nigeria, these are citizens aged 18 or above who have registered with the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC). Beyond this legal status, digital-election research treats electorates as audiences whose readings of campaign messages are shaped by identity, experience, media exposure and prior attitudes, rather than as uniformly persuadable voters (Kleinnijenhuis et al., 2019; Venus et al., 2025). In this study, electorates are registered voters resident in the six South-South states (Akwa Ibom, Bayelsa, Cross River, Delta, Edo and Rivers) who actively use social media and belong to Generation Z (born 1997 - 2012; aged 18 - 29 at the time of the study) or the Millennial cohort (born 1981 - 1996; aged 30 - 45). Electorates' responses are broader than persuasion: exposure to a campaign message may produce recognition, scepticism, humour, distrust or emotion without any change in voting preference (Conrad et al., 2025; Gondwe, 2025; Gallegos et al., 2026). Responses are therefore operationalised as electorates' recognition, interpretations, trust judgements, emotions and stated voting intentions following exposure.

AI-generated campaign messages are better conceptualised by production process, not falsity: generative systems can create or substantially transform political text, images, audio and video, whether truthful, satirical or deceptive (Goldstein et al., 2024; abuz & Nehring, 2024). Operationally, they are study stimuli generated or materially synthesised using generative-AI tools.

Human-created campaign messages cannot simply mean "authentic": humans also manipulate, selectively frame and strategically persuade. Their analytical value is therefore comparative authorship rather than presumed truthfulness, especially because AI labels themselves can alter credibility judgements (Gallegos et al., 2026; Goldstein et al., 2024; Schiff et al., 2025). In this study, they are campaign stimuli produced through conventional human recording, photography or design without generative-AI synthesis.

Recognition and Interpretation of Campaign Messages

Experimental research suggests that the key question is not whether electorates can "spot AI", but which cues they rely on to assess authorship and meaning (Groh et al., 2022; Stefkovics & Gere, 2026). Groh et al. (2022) observed, in five experiments, that audio-visual cues, more than content alone, determined whether deepfake political videos were recognised. In contrast, across 27 European countries, Stefkovics and Gere (2026) found little difference in how respondents reacted to human- and AI-generated headlines when authorship was undisclosed, suggesting that text-based synthetic content is hard to distinguish. This is further complicated in Africa by fragile information environments, as evidenced by high levels of perceived exposure to disinformation and low trust in social and national media in Kenya (Wack & Prochaska, 2026), Nigeria (Ngoka et al., 2026) and South Africa (Mtsweni et al., 2023). Thus, in Sub-Saharan Africa, recognition is likely to occur under general suspicion rather than confident, positive identification. During the 2023 presidential election, misinformation in Nigeria involved the dissemination of fabricated information, as well as the use of "fake-news" labels, prebunking and debunking terms to challenge rival statements by campaign actors (Ibrahim & Ekdale, 2026). Thus, South-South electorates might use partisan identity, pre-existing beliefs, language, platform cues, and perceived authenticity, rather than just the technology being used, to interpret a message as AI-generated.

Trust in AI-Generated and Human-Created Campaign Messages

Trust is shaped less by whether a message is objectively AI-generated than by what voters believe its source and production process imply. In US - UK experiments, Altay and Gilardi (2024) found that an "AI-generated" label reduced perceived accuracy and sharing intentions even when content was true or human-written. Further, internet use has been associated with lower institutional trust and weaker perceptions of democracy, suggesting that digital distrust predates generative AI and may condition reactions to it (Wang et al., 2023; Wen et al., 2025). Adeleke (2025) documents the circulation of deepfake audio during the 2023 elections, showing how synthetic media can weaken confidence not only in false content but also in authentic recordings. More locally, Abdulazeez, Anthony and Iwegbue (2026) found that South-South voters' trust in algorithm-curated political messages varied with exposure and demographic factors. However, their cross-sectional design cannot establish causality. This exploratory study therefore attends to whether participants distinguish distrust of AI authorship from distrust of parties, platforms, candidates and Nigeria's political information system.

Emotional Responses and Voting Intentions

Evidence cautions against technological determinism, even though AI-generated campaign messages can engage voters through emotional and personalised persuasion. Conrad et al. (2025) note that politically produced AI images may be more likely to induce attention and emotional processing, and reactions to them

may be largely attributable to their perceived humanness and trustworthiness. But emotional arousal does not necessarily lead to lasting change in voting behaviour; most experiments report shifts in attitudes rather than behaviour at the polls. In Africa, the 2024 South African election offers a warning: Gondwe (2025) analysed 22,384 messages from politically engaged WhatsApp groups and found that AI-generated deepfakes interacted with emotional manipulation and group ideology to construct false narratives, showing that AI content works relationally through partisan communities, platform dynamics, and grievances.

However, such results cannot be transferred wholesale to Nigeria, where ethnic, religious, regional and party identities shape political choice. Nigerian studies of the 2023 presidential election show that religion and party politics influenced candidate choice alongside social-media engagement, with variation across regions (Morah & Nwafor, 2024; Salahu, 2023; Baba & Jibril, 2023), while Ngoka et al. (2026) reported that WhatsApp campaigns affected the turnout of University of Nigeria students, although this single-university study has limited transferability. The open question for South-South Nigeria is whether AI shapes emotional intensity and voting intention beyond source identity, partisanship, and social-media exposure.

Theoretical Framework

Source Credibility Theory, developed by Hovland et al. (1953) from Hovland and Weiss's (1951) experiments on communicator credibility, holds that messages influence audiences more when the source is perceived as knowledgeable (expertise) and honest (trustworthiness). It has since been widely applied in advertising, journalism, health and political communication, although a review of five decades of evidence shows that credibility effects are conditional: they weaken when audiences are highly involved with the issue, hold strong prior attitudes, or learn the source only after the message (Pornpitakpan, 2004). Two further limitations matter here. First, credibility is perceived rather than fixed and can be distorted by beliefs, partisanship and context. Second, the theory assumes an identifiable human communicator. Generative AI unsettles this assumption, because audiences may judge a message by cues about the technology itself, sometimes applying a "machine heuristic" that treats machine-made content as more objective (Sundar, 2008), even as AI labels can lower perceived accuracy (Altay & Gilardi, 2024). Consistent with the exploratory design, the theory is used as a sensitising rather than a testing framework: it directs attention to how participants judge the expertise, honesty and authenticity behind AI-generated and human-created messages, and whether these judgements relate to their trust, emotional responses and voting intentions, while leaving room for explanations the theory does not anticipate.

Method

This study adopted a qualitative exploratory design. Exploratory research suits new phenomena about which little is known, where the aim is to discover how people understand an issue and to generate propositions for later testing, rather than to measure prevalence or test hypotheses (Stebbins, 2001). Because AI-generated campaign messages are new in Nigerian elections and no prior study had examined how South-South electorates read them, the study did not seek to estimate how the region's millions of registered voters respond, which would require a large probability-based survey. Instead, it sought an in-depth account of how electorates understood, trusted and emotionally responded to AI-generated and human-created campaign messages, allowing participants to explain why particular messages appeared credible, artificial or persuasive (Braun & Clarke, 2022; Keen et al., 2022).

Participants and Sampling

Nineteen participants (see Table 1) were purposively recruited from active political groups across social media. Inclusion criteria were that participants were aged 18 or above, were registered voters with INEC,

resided in one of the six South-South states, used social media daily and were regularly exposed to political content online. Participants were spread evenly across all six states, with three or four from each. Maximum-variation sampling was used to capture differences in age, gender, occupation and experience with AI-generated content. Online recruitment and interviewing made it possible to reach participants across the region, a recognised strength of virtual qualitative research (Keen et al., 2022). Sample size was guided by information power rather than statistical representativeness: a focused aim, a specific participant group, rich dialogue and an established analytic strategy reduce the number of participants needed (Malterud et al., 2016), and empirical tests show that interview studies with relatively homogeneous groups often reach saturation within 9 - 17 interviews (Hennink & Kaiser, 2022). Participants are identified by letter codes.

Table 1: Characteristics of Participants

Characteristic	Category	Frequency (n)	Percentage (%)
Total respondents		19	100.0
Gender	Female	11	57.9
	Male	8	42.1
Age profile	18 - 22 years	5	26.3
	23 - 27 years	4	21.1
	28 - 32 years	4	21.1
	33 - 36 years	3	15.8
	37 - 40 years	3	15.8
Primary occupational status	Student	4	21.1
	Student with additional employm...	4	21.1
	Employed professional	3	15.8
	Trader/self-employed	3	15.8
	Model/affiliate marketer	3	15.8
	Other skilled/self-employed occu...	2	10.5
Social media use	Daily/frequent users	19	100.0
Interaction with AI-generated co...	Deliberately seeks/uses AI-gener...	12	63.2
	Encounters AI mainly through al...	7	36.8

Data Collection

Data were collected through online semi-structured interviews. Each participant was presented with six campaign messages, labelled CM1 to CM6, comprising both AI-generated and human-created materials in video and still-image formats. The researcher observed participants as they watched the materials and noted immediate reactions such as laughter, hesitation, surprise and confusion. Follow-up questions explored what they noticed, believed, trusted, felt and whether the messages could affect their voting intentions.

Data Analysis

The data were analysed using Braun and Clarke's (2022) six-phase reflexive thematic analysis, an approach suited to exploring patterns of meaning in small, in-depth datasets. First, transcripts and observation notes were read repeatedly for familiarisation. Second, relevant statements were coded. Third, related codes were grouped into possible themes; thus, the themes emerged from the data rather than being predetermined. Fourth, the themes were checked against the full dataset. Fifth, they were refined and clearly named. Finally,

the findings were written using representative quotations. Consistent with the exploratory design, the analysis aimed at transferable insight and theoretical propositions rather than statistical generalisation.

Results

Three themes were developed from the data. Consistent with the exploratory design, they describe patterns within this sample of 19 participants and are not intended to estimate how widely these views are held among South-South electorates.

Theme 1: Recognition and Interpretation of Campaign Messages

Among the 19 participants, recognition of AI-generated campaign materials was largely anchored in perceived departures from normal human movement, facial expression, voice, setting and political reality. QR, for instance, claimed complete confidence, identifying "a watermark in the video that clearly shows that it was made with an AI tool... the body movements, they were not realistic". Similarly, AB rated his ability 10/10 because "AI itself, no matter how good it is, currently doesn't capture [human behaviour and tone] to its best." CM, CD and AC also cited appearance, body movement, intonation, video quality, facial expression and background as diagnostic cues.

The most frequently identified example was CM1, the politicians' race. FG judged it artificial because "I don't think our president is young enough to be sprinting", DD pointed to the exaggerated leg split, and AP, PM and MN to unnatural speed and movement. MN was particularly attentive to behavioural consistency, noting that "Peter Obi was laughing to the end and Tinubu wasn't laughing from the beginning to the end... there should be signs that shows that there is something going on." Recognition was thus not only technical: participants compared what they saw with their knowledge of normal bodies and of the candidates.

Contextual plausibility also shaped interpretation. The communion video was repeatedly challenged: TA described "different celebrities receiving communion from a presidential aspirant as a priest" as an obvious impossibility, while CG stated simply: "I have not seen a Muslim in church taking Holy Communion before." These accounts indicate that participants identified AI not only through visual aberrations, but also through breaches of social, religious and political norms.

In contrast, CM3 and CM6 were typically seen as human-made because they resembled familiar campaign environments in Nigeria. AY explained that CM3 "shows the normal campaign settings... many, many voters and then she's talking to the crowd," while RA described CM3 and CM6 as "natural... realistic." For CG, CD and AC, visible crowds, recognisable campaign practices and spontaneous reactions signalled human production, while NA looked for correspondence between voice and emotion, and CF for source credibility and factual traceability.

Yet recognition was not universal. FG, AY,QB, PG, TA, RA, AC and CF all struggled with at least one static image, particularly the flag image, suggesting that static AI imagery was harder to classify than moving video. CF captured this ambiguity: "the picture was not factual... there were faces on the Nigerian flag, and we all know there are no faces on the Nigerian flag." Likewise, NA rated himself only 6/10 because "sometimes AI... looks more real," while RA rated herself 4/10 due to the increasingly advanced generation. For these participants, recognition was a layered process that became less reliable as the technology improved.

Theme 2: Trust and Credibility of Campaign Messages

Participants' perceptions of authenticity, realism, source plausibility, emotional connection, and perceived human presence were primary drivers of trust, and human-created materials were generally trusted more than AI-generated ones. PG expressed this clearly: "the human-generated political material... looked real, authentic,

I could easily connect to it", whereas the AI materials appeared "very fake... it did not look real." DD similarly trusted the human-created videos because "you could actually relate to what was happening." Credibility was thus often established by perceived human realism rather than by the message itself.

This preference was especially noticeable for CM3 and CM6. AY trusted CM3 because "it shows a normal voting system, normal election process, normal campaign settings", RA trusted CM3 and CM6 simply "because they are real", and CD explained that CM3 "looked so real and the environment was very natural."

However, trust did not depend solely on human production. AP found AI-generated CM4 convincing because "the message passed through that material is very genuine and clear" and spoke directly to Nigeria's present circumstances. PM trusted CM4 because it conveyed grief and sadness, while CF trusted the same content because of its emotional resonance: "it kind of told a story... it was emotionally connecting... I was moved by it." These responses blur a clear-cut division between AI and human content: where AI content depicted recognisable social realities, its message could outweigh its production method.

Distrust of AI nonetheless remained common. QA questioned the race material because "it looked very unreal and untrue", while TA stressed that looking believable did not mean political acceptance: "Credible in terms of, do I, would I vote for these people? No." NA doubted even CM2 and CM3, showing that realistic-looking scenes could prompt verification rather than automatic acceptance.

Several participants also linked credibility to AI's distortion of known reality. QR rejected CM2 because "we all know Tinubu is a Muslim... that would be unbelievable," while CG similarly distrusted the communion scenario. CF further distinguished emotional believability from factual credibility, noting that some materials were "believable, but... not factual." Overall, credibility was built from visual realism, familiarity, emotional appeal, factual consistency, perceived source authenticity and alignment with participants' experience of political life.

Theme 3: Emotional and Behavioural Influence of Campaign Messages

The campaign materials produced markedly different emotional responses, which did not always translate into voting intentions. Humour, confusion, hope, interest, worry and indifference were all evident, with AI-generated materials more often provoking amusement or scepticism, and human-created materials more often eliciting interest and connection. PG described the AI-generated race video as "very funny because it's not something I would usually see", but the human-generated campaign event produced "a little bit of excitement" because of the visible turnout, suggesting that some AI content functioned more as political entertainment than as persuasion.

Yet humour could weaken behavioural influence. DD said that if a candidate used AI-generated videos, "I would take the person as not being serious", because elections should involve "bringing people together for a common purpose." CG asked: "why not do it real time?" For these participants, artificiality signalled insufficient political seriousness.

Other participants experienced more substantive emotions. AP felt hopeful because CM4 addressed current national conditions: "if we do what is right, we elect, we vote for the good candidates, there will still be hope in our country." AC also felt hopeful, while RA said the materials increased her "interest in politics because of the way the APC campaigned." CF was moved by the bloodstained flag, indicating that even AI-generated material could generate affective engagement where its symbolism resonated with participants' understanding of national hardship.

Conversely, confusion and worry arose where messages were ambiguous or exaggerated. MN said CM1 left him confused because "the campaign portrays everybody to be active", making it difficult to determine "who

is good for the job." PM doubted the campaign's sincerity: "I don't want a situation where they will make all these things and still turn their back on us." NA worried that images of candidates pushing one another suggested political hostility.

However, emotional engagement did not uniformly produce persuasion. TA remained "indifferent" because "if this is a campaign video, there should be a message. There was no message," adding that the materials made the candidates appear "not very serious." QR said the materials had no political effect because "they are not persuasive," and CF explained: "videos will not change my view"; she would instead assess candidates through "the way you speak and your past performances."

In contrast, AY, QB, AB, RA, AC and CD indicated that campaign materials could influence their electoral judgement. AY said a meaningful manifesto delivered before a crowd would make her "listen... and be looking forward to seeing what you accomplish when you get into the office." AB acknowledged that even AI-generated portrayals influenced his perception of President Tinubu because they "draw a parallel line to what we are facing in Nigeria." Within this sample, behavioural influence depended less on emotion alone than on whether emotion was reinforced by message relevance, perceived authenticity, candidate credibility and prior political judgement.

Discussion

On the first objective, the findings suggest that recognition was contextual and embodied rather than purely technical. Participants flagged unnatural movements, mismatched laughter and breaches of known religious or political facts, as when CG questioned a Muslim aspirant administering Communion. This aligns with Groh et al. (2022), who showed that audio-visual anomalies, not just content, drive deepfake detection. It appears to contrast with Stefkovics and Gere's (2026) 27-country survey, which found little difference in judgements of undisclosed AI and human content; however, their stimuli were text headlines lacking the embodied cues participants here relied on. Consistent with this, participants such as CF struggled most with still images, suggesting that recognition confidence declines as AI content offers fewer cues to check against lived experience.

On the second objective, participants generally trusted human-created content more, rejecting AI content as unreal (PG, DD). This echoes Altay and Gilardi (2024), whose participants discounted content labelled as AI-generated even when it was accurate. However, AP and PM judged the AI-generated CM4 credible because it reflected Nigeria's current challenges. This complicates reliance on labelling: where the source is unclear, emotional relevance can act as a credibility cue. In terms of Source Credibility Theory (Hovland et al., 1953), source characteristics appeared to matter most when the source was clear, while relevance substituted for them when it was ambiguous. Moreover, whereas Abdulazeez et al. 's (2026) cross-sectional data could not separate believability from willingness to vote, TA explicitly distinguished distrust of AI from distrust of politicians.

On the third and fourth objectives, AI-generated content more often evoked humour or scepticism (as in DD's reaction to the race video), while human-generated content evoked interest or excitement (PG, RA). Emotion seldom translated into voting intention: TA, QR and CF reacted emotionally yet found the material unpersuasive, consistent with Conrad et al. (2025), who warn that increased emotional processing does not necessarily produce lasting behaviour change. This differs from Gondwe (2025), who found AI deepfakes actively spread through partisan WhatsApp groups in South Africa. The contrast may reflect method rather than context: Gondwe examined organic network diffusion, while these interviews captured reflective judgement within a Nigerian identity politics in which religion and party already shape choice (Morah & Nwafor, 2024; Salahu, 2023; Baba & Jibril, 2023).

Taken together, these exploratory results suggest an extension of Source Credibility Theory, which assumes an

identifiable source: participants first determined whether a human source was present, then evaluated its honesty and expertise. Recognition, trust and emotional response therefore appear sequential rather than parallel, a layering that the literature on AI and African elections, largely concerned with disinformation risk (Wack & Prochaska, 2026; Ibrahim & Ekdale, 2026), does not fully theorise. These are propositions to be tested in larger, representative studies rather than conclusions about South-South electorates as a whole.

Implications

Although exploratory, the findings suggest that AI-generated political campaign content can influence electorates, even when they are aware of its artificial nature. This is relevant to Nigeria's 2027 elections, particularly for young electorates, political parties, electoral bodies, journalists and fact-checkers. Participants detected AI content through errors, unrealistic behaviour and violations of familiar political or religious contexts, but these cues will become less reliable as AI improves. Convincing synthetic videos or images could damage reputations, erode trust and deepen existing political and religious divisions. Political parties should therefore use AI transparently, while INEC, media organisations and civil society groups should strengthen voter education and fast fact-checking.

Limitations and Directions for Future Research

As an exploratory qualitative study, this research has limitations that define how its findings should be read. The sample of 19 purposively selected, social-media-active registered voters aged 18 - 40 is not statistically representative, and the findings should not be generalised to all South-South electorates; they offer transferable insights and propositions instead. The participants also responded to selected campaign materials in an interview setting rather than during an actual campaign, where party allegiance, peer pressure and repeated exposure may shape responses differently. Future research should test the propositions generated here through larger, probability-based surveys of registered voters across all six states, experiments comparing AI-generated and human-created messages, and studies conducted during the campaign season.

Conclusion

This exploratory study suggests that the South-South electorates interviewed did not judge campaign messages by technology alone. They recognised AI through embodied and contextual cues, trusted messages that felt real and relevant, and rarely allowed emotional reactions to override prior political judgement. As AI-generated content becomes harder to detect, these patterns warrant confirmatory research ahead of the 2027 general elections.

References

1. Abboud, E., Ajwang, F., & Lugano, G. (2024). Social media and politics as usual? Exploring the role of social media in the 2022 Kenyan presidential election. Journal of Eastern African Studies, 18(2), 321 - 343.

2. Abdulazeez, I., Anthony, O. U., & Iwegbue, G. U. (2026). Exposure and trust in online political messages in the age of social media algorithms among voters in South-South, Nigeria. International Journal of Sub-Saharan African Research, 4(1), 511 - 527.

3. Adeleke, F. (2025). Reinstating trust in elections in the era of artificial intelligence and emerging technologies. Data & Policy, 7, e38.

4. Altay, S., & Gilardi, F. (2024). People are skeptical of headlines labeled as AI-generated, even if true or human-made, because they assume full AI automation. PNAS Nexus, 3(10), Article pgae403.

5. Baba, M. S., & Jibril, Z. A. (2023). The intersection of religion and politics in the 2023 presidential election in Nigeria: A case study of Adamawa State. ADSU International Journal of Applied Economics, Finance and Management, 8(2), 130 - 150.

6. Bai, H., Voelkel, J. G., Muldowney, S., Eichstaedt, J. C., & Willer, R. (2025). LLM-generated messages can persuade humans on policy issues. Nature Communications, 16(1), Article 6037. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-025-61345-5

7. Beacken, G. D., Trauthig, I. K., & Woolley, S. C. (2026). Generative AI, propaganda, and digital authoritarianism: Comparative insights from six democratically weakened countries. Big Data & Society, 13(2).

8. Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2022). Conceptual and design thinking for thematic analysis. Qualitative Psychology, 9(1), 3 - 26.

9. Cariolle, J., Elkhateeb, Y., & Maurel, M. (2024). Misinformation technology: Internet use and political misperceptions in Africa. Journal of Comparative Economics, 52(2), 400 - 433. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jce.2024.01.002

10. Conrad, C., Nissen, A., Masoumi-Ravandi, K., Ramchandani, M., Braga, R. F., & Newman, A. (2025). Do truthfulness notifications influence perceptions of AI-generated political images? A cognitive investigation with EEG. Computers in Human Behavior: Artificial Humans, Article 100185.

11. Ekanem, I., & Nwagbara, U. (2024). AI-generated advertising in Nigeria: A qualitative exploration of consumer perceptions, trust, and engagement. TSU Journal of Communication and Media Studies, 4(1), 1 - 18.

12. Fisher, J., Gadjanova, E., & Hitchen, J. (2024). WhatsApp and political communication in West Africa: Accounting for differences in parties' organization and message discipline online. Party Politics, 30(5), 934 - 948.

13. Gadjanova, E., Lynch, G., & Saibu, G. (2022). Misinformation across digital divides: Theory and evidence from northern Ghana. African Affairs, 121(483), 161 - 195.

14. Gallegos, I. O., Shani, C., Shi, W., Bianchi, F., Gainsburg, I., Jurafsky, D., & Willer, R. (2026). Labeling messages as AI-generated does not reduce their persuasive effects. PNAS Nexus, 5(2), Article pgag008.

15. Goldstein, J. A., Chao, J., Grossman, S., Stamos, A., & Tomz, M. (2024). How persuasive is AI-generated propaganda? PNAS Nexus, 3(2), Article pgae034.

16. Gondwe, G. (2025). AI-driven disinformation and political influence on WhatsApp in South Africa's 2024 elections. The International Journal of Press/Politics. Advance online publication.

17. Groh, M., Epstein, Z., Firestone, C., & Picard, R. (2022). Deepfake detection by human crowds, machines, and machine-informed crowds. Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, 119(1), Article e2110013119.

18. Hassim, M. N., & Nasir, N. N. A. M. (2025). The role of AI in shaping political discourse on social media. International Journal of Research and Innovation in Social Science (IJRISS), 9(10). https://doi.org/10.47772/IJRISS.2025.910000478

19. Hennink, M., & Kaiser, B. N. (2022). Sample sizes for saturation in qualitative research: A systematic review of empirical tests. Social Science & Medicine, 292, 114523.

20. Hovland, C. I., & Weiss, W. (1951). The influence of source credibility on communication effectiveness. Public Opinion Quarterly, 15(4), 635 - 650.

21. Hovland, C. I., Janis, I. L., & Kelley, H. H. (1953). Communication and persuasion. Yale University Press.

22. Ibrahim, A. A., & Ekdale, B. (2026). Political campaign responses to information disorder: A case study of the 2023 Nigerian presidential elections. The International Journal of Press/Politics, 31(3), 595 - 615.

23. Jungherr, A., Rauchfleisch, A., & Wuttke, A. (2026). Artificial intelligence in election campaigns: Perceptions, penalties, and implications. Political Communication, 43(4), 585 - 606.

24. Keen, S., Lomeli-Rodriguez, M., & Joffe, H. (2022). From challenge to opportunity: Virtual qualitative research during COVID-19 and beyond. International Journal of Qualitative Methods, 21.

25. Kleinnijenhuis, J., van Hoof, A. M., & van Atteveldt, W. (2019). The combined effects of mass media and social media on political perceptions and preferences. Journal of Communication, 69(6), 650 - 673.

26. abuz, M., & Nehring, C. (2024). On the way to deep fake democracy? Deep fakes in election campaigns in 2023. European Political Science, 23(4), 454 - 473.

27. Malterud, K., Siersma, V. D., & Guassora, A. D. (2016). Sample size in qualitative interview studies: Guided by information power. Qualitative Health Research, 26(13), 1753 - 1760.

28. Morah, D. N., & Nwafor, O. A. (2024). Beyond tribal politics for e-participation and development: Social media influence on Nigeria's 2023 presidential general election. Journal of Innovative Digital Transformation, 1(1), 32 - 47.

29. Mtsweni, J., Ndlovu, L., Mthethwa, S., & Mkuzangwe, N. (2023). Measuring misinformation trends on social media in South Africa using machine learning. In Proceedings of the International Conference on Artificial Intelligence and its Applications (pp. 128 - 133).

30. Muringa, T., & Adjin-Tettey, T. D. (2024). Media literacy's role in democratic engagement and societal transformation among university students. African Journalism Studies, 45(2), 115 - 134.

31. Mustapha, M. J., Lasisi, M. I., & Barabash, V. V. (2024). Are they tools? Anglophone West African countries' students' misconception of media literacy and critical thinking for combating misinformation. Journal of Media Literacy Education, 16(1), 94 - 103.

32. Ngoka, R. O., Ezeani, E. O., Ugwuozor, I. S., & Ezeani, U. K. (2026). Interrogating the impact of the use of WhatsApp on the voting behaviour of University of Nigeria, Nsukka students during the 2023 Nigerian presidential election. Journal of Asian and African Studies, 61(1), 653 - 674.

33. Nwaoboli, E. P., & Ojete, E. (2025). Critical analysis of AI-generated video content and its influence on Peter Obi's social identity formation in Nigeria's 2023 presidential election. Zaria Journal of Communication, 9(2), 23 - 41.

34. Pornpitakpan, C. (2004). The persuasiveness of source credibility: A critical review of five decades' evidence. Journal of Applied Social Psychology, 34(2), 243 - 281.

35. Salahu, M. O. (2023). Politics, religion and electoral outcomes in Nigeria: The 2023 presidential election in perspective. Journal of Administrative Science, 20(1), 213 - 233.

36. Schiff, K. J., Schiff, D. S., & Bueno, N. S. (2025). The liar's dividend: Can politicians claim misinformation to evade accountability? American Political Science Review, 119(1), 71 - 90.

37. Stebbins, R. A. (2001). Exploratory research in the social sciences. Sage.

38. Stefkovics, Á., & Gere, D. (2026). Beliefs and sharing intentions of human- and AI-generated fake news: Evidence from 27 European countries. PNAS Nexus, 5(3), Article pgag032.

39. Sundar, S. S. (2008). The MAIN model: A heuristic approach to understanding technology effects on credibility. In M. J. Metzger & A. J. Flanagin (Eds.), Digital media, youth, and credibility (pp. 73 - 100). MIT Press.

40. Uwalaka, T., Amadi, F., & Enyindah, S. C. (2025). Social media influencers and political influence operations: The Data Boys example in Nigeria. Public Relations Inquiry, 14(1), 89 - 115.

41. Uzuegbunam, C. E. (2026). Future-proofing emerging technologies (artificial intelligence) in sub-Saharan African democracy. In The Routledge companion to digital media and democracy (pp. 439 - 451). Routledge.

42. Venus, A., Intyaswati, D., Ayuningtyas, F., & Lestari, P. (2025). Political participation in the digital age: Impact of influencers and advertising on Generation Z. Cogent Arts & Humanities, 12(1), Article 2520063.

43. \Wack, M., & Parry, D. A. (2025). Synthetic diversity: Examining the effects of ethnic targeting using AI-generated political ads. International Journal of Communication, 19, 25.

44. Wack, M., & Prochaska, S. (2026). Making sense of AI-generated disinformation: How audience interpretations influence the impact of deepfakes in Kenya. Social Media + Society, 12(3).

45. Wang, Z., Liu, H., Li, T., Zhou, L., & Zhou, M. (2023). The impact of internet use on citizens' trust in government: The mediating role of sense of security. Systems, 11(1), Article 47.

46. Wen, Y., Sun, X., & Fang, L. (2025). The impact of internet use in the digital era on public political trust in China: An empirical study based on CGSS 2021 data. PLOS ONE, 20(12), Article e0339999.